

Chapter 29 - Gathering

On the morning of the housewarming party¹, Feng Yue got up early, and Zhou Qiongqiong, who had delivered a housewarming gift the previous day and stayed overnight, also rose early with her.

Zhou Qiongqiong opened the guest room door with disheveled hair and a tired expression, then leisurely walked to the kitchen entrance.

Seeing her, Feng Yue asked, "Is it okay to have sandwiches for breakfast?"

Zhou Qiongqiong waved her hand and yawned, "I don't need breakfast in the morning, just a cup of coffee will do."

"I only have instant coffee at home. If you're not used to it, should I order takeout for you?"

"Instant is fine too, I'm not picky, just need something to wake me up."

"Alright, I'll make you a cup. Go wash up."

"Okay, thanks." Zhou Qiongqiong smiled and waved at Feng Yue.

Feng Yue smiled without saying anything.

By the time Zhou Qiongqiong finished getting ready and came out, there was already a steaming cup of coffee on the dining table. She picked it up and took a sip to refresh herself, then sat down to chat with Feng Yue.

Zhou Qiongqiong looked at the soft sofa she had brought, feeling quite pleased, "I didn't get to properly try that sofa yesterday, you must sit on it more today."

Feng Yue laughed, "There's no need to rush it right now. Since you've given it to me, I'll have plenty of time to sit on it in the future."

"That's true." Zhou Qiongqiong leaned back, "Ah, you have no idea how many friends I had to go through to get this sofa, but I finally managed to buy it."

"Yes, this humble servant will definitely make good use of the sofa that Young Miss Zhou has bestowed!" As she spoke, Feng Yue playfully cupped her hands in a salute.

The sofa was warm yellow, and Feng Yue had spread a fluffy blanket on top of it. It looked comfortable and warm, perfect for curling up in during winter.

This small single-person sofa had indeed made Zhou Qiongqiong go through several friends, as she had said.

The sofa was specially chosen by her - her friend told her it was handcrafted in Italy, and it had just been shipped back to China last night, which was why Zhou Qiongqiong had delivered it to Feng Yue's house along with the sofa late at night.

"By the way, what time are they arriving today? Do we need to go out and buy anything?" Zhou Qiongqiong put down her cup and asked.

Feng Yue shook her head, "Xiaoxue and Sister Wenzhen should arrive around meal time, and I have another friend coming after lunch. She's been busy with her graduation thesis² and can't get away."

"You have a college student friend? Your social circle is quite wide." Zhou Qiongqiong was a bit surprised.

"What are you talking about? She's just a younger sister I knew before. I usually get along well with her. She's been very busy lately, so this is also a way for her to come out and relax."

"That's nice. All in all, it's just five people - not too many, not too few."

"Yeah."

After breakfast, Zhou Qiongqiong helped clean up the kitchen, and Feng Yue began preparing to shoot video footage.

Zhou Qiongqiong didn't understand these things very well, so she could only act as an obedient assistant, going wherever Feng Yue pointed.

Wenzhen had already helped her adjust the camera parameters and lighting setup beforehand, so now she just needed to arrange things in the right positions, and they could start filming directly when the time came.

However, since this was Feng Yue's first time actually handling these things and her first time shooting a video, she and Zhou Qiongqiong were both fumbling around chaotically for quite a while.

Fortunately, Wenzhen arrived earlier than expected, and Feng Yue felt like she had found her savior, quickly welcoming her in.

Wenzhen was holding a housewarming gift for Feng Yue, "This is a housewarming present." She handed over what she was carrying.

Feng Yue received the tightly wrapped object that looked very much like a picture frame with both hands, politely thanking her, "Thank you, Sister Wenzhen, please come in quickly."

Zhou Qiongqiong had originally been fiddling with the pile of photography equipment, but when she heard Wenzhen's voice, she quickly poked her head out from the kitchen, "Senior sister, you're here."

Wenzhen had thought she would definitely be the first to arrive, so when she saw Zhou Qiongqiong, a flash of surprise crossed her eyes, "You came so early? That's not like you."

Zhou Qiongqiong smiled, "I stayed overnight at Ayue's house yesterday, so I got up a bit early today."

Feng Yue nodded and told Wenzhen about what had happened the night before.

"That's so you." Wenzhen stepped forward and patted Zhou Qiongqiong's shoulder.

"Sister Wenzhen, can I unwrap it now?" Feng Yue crouched on the ground, curious about what was underneath the covered frame.

Seeing this, Zhou Qiongqiong also came closer, "Is this a gift from senior sister? What is it?"

"Unwrap it and see if you like it." Wenzhen's eyes curved with a smile.

With Wenzhen's words, Feng Yue no longer hesitated and began removing the paper covering the frame from the back.

The cardboard blocking the air was removed, revealing the gift's true appearance.

It was an oil painting with delicate brushstrokes and warm tones, depicting a sunrise scene. Under that brilliant morning sun was a dense and vibrant forest.

"Wow!" Zhou Qiongqiong, being an artist, couldn't help but exclaim in admiration. The reason was simple - this painting matched Feng Yue's home decoration perfectly.

Feng Yue's eyes sparkled as she looked at the painting. She turned to look at Wenzhen, "Thank you, Sister Wenzhen! I really love this painting!"

Wenzhen smiled with satisfaction, "I'm glad you like it."

Zhou Qiongqiong said from the side, "Senior sister, I remember you minored in oil painting in college, right? Did you paint this yourself?"

"Mm, I haven't picked up a brush in a long time, so it's not as detailed as before."

"Not at all! It's beautiful!" Feng Yue stood up happily, holding the painting with both hands, comparing it here and there. She wanted to find the most suitable place to hang the painting.

Seeing that she couldn't bear to put the painting down for even a moment, Zhou Qiongqiong laughed, "That's enough for now, you still have important things to do."

Only then did Feng Yue come back to her senses - she still hadn't finished setting up the photography equipment in the kitchen.

However, now that Wenzhen was there to help, Feng Yue and Zhou Qiongqiong weren't so flustered anymore. Zhou Qiongqiong didn't even want to step into the kitchen, leaving the professional to help inside while she went to the living room to watch TV.

Shooting videos was a very troublesome task, but fortunately Feng Yue had written a script in advance. Although it was rough, it was better than nothing.

It wasn't until Feng Yue had finished filming all the food preparation scenes according to the script that she had time to watch the footage with Wenzhen.

In the several video clips, only Feng Yue's hands appeared on camera, with her and Wenzhen's occasional voices as background audio.

With Wenzhen's help, the quality of the footage was much better than Feng Yue had imagined. Whether it was lighting or capturing the scenes, it all showed Wenzhen's powerful camera skills.

"Sister Wenzhen, you're amazing! This far exceeded my expectations!" Feng Yue praised her generously.

Wenzhen smiled and unhesitatingly accepted her praise, then carefully explained things to pay attention to when filming.

After the two finished preparing the ingredients needed for lunch, the doorbell rang again shortly after.

It should be Fu Sixue arriving.

Feng Yue put down what she was doing in the kitchen and hurried to open the door.

Everything Fu Sixue brought was food - one was a fondant cake she had custom-made, shaped like a large flat, with decorations and item arrangements inside that could almost find enlarged versions in Feng Yue's home. The other was a bottle of red wine she had randomly picked from her father's wine cellar.

"Happy housewarming, Moon! This cake was designed by me personally and then custom-made. Doesn't it look like an enlarged version of your home?" Fu Sixue proudly curved her lips.

"You've only been to my house a few times, but you're so amazing!" Feng Yue looked at the cake in her hands and couldn't help but exclaim in admiration.

"Sigh, there's nothing I can do. I just have a bit of photographic memory."

"Yes, yes, yes, Miss Genius."

Fu Sixue nodded with satisfaction, entered the door, greeted everyone, then happily threw herself onto the sofa to catch up with Zhou Qiongqiong.

Now that everyone was here, Feng Yue immediately began cooking. Originally, Wenzhen wanted to stay in the kitchen to help, but Feng Yue drove her out on the grounds that she was a guest.

So the kitchen was left with only the photography equipment that had been set up and busy Feng Yue.

Back when Feng Yue wanted to make Yan Lin eat better and be happier, she had put considerable effort into learning to cook.

So before long, an aroma drifted from the kitchen into the noses of the three people sitting in the living room.

Fu Sixue sprawled on the sofa like she had no bones, and after smelling the aroma, she twitched her nose and touched her stomach, "Ah - I'm so hungry, smelling this makes me even hungrier."

"Didn't you eat breakfast?" Zhou Qiongqiong asked.

"No, I didn't go to bed until 2 AM last night. When I got up today, I went straight to pick up the cake and then came directly here. I didn't even have a chance to eat breakfast." Fu Sixue propped her chin with one hand, looking pitiful.

"You should still eat something in the morning, otherwise your stomach won't be able to handle it in the future." Wenzhen advised from the side.

"I can't cook, and I don't want to order takeout in the morning, so I just sleep and go hungry."

Zhou Qiongqiong was curious, "What about lunch and dinner?"

Fu Sixue recalled, "When I was abroad, I lived at home so I didn't have this problem. After returning to China, I seem to have been eating convenience foods and takeout back and forth, occasionally going out for meals with friends."

"Poor you, baby." Zhou Qiongqiong dramatically reached out to hug Fu Sixue.

Fu Sixue was amused by her and couldn't break free from her arms, so she could only reach toward Wenzhen for escape.

Wenzhen had a good impression of Fu Sixue and was happy to join in their playfulness. She reached out to rescue Fu Sixue from Zhou Qiongqiong's embrace and asked, "Haven't you thought about hiring an auntie³ to take care of your daily life? Living like this will make you sick in the long run."

"Sigh, there's nothing I can do. I don't like strangers coming to my house."

Zhou Qiongqiong laughed, "Pfft, then your future partner can't come to your house either?"

"What kind of stranger is a partner?"

"That's true." Zhou Qiongqiong leaned back against the sofa, "But if you want to find a boyfriend who can take care of you, it doesn't seem very easy. He'd have to know how to cook and be able to take care of you."

"Hm? Boyfriend? I never said I like men." As she spoke, Fu Sixue slightly curved her lips.

Zhou Qiongqiong, Wenzhen: ?

So suddenly, she came out?

"I like beautiful, gentle big sisters who can cook." Fu Sixue curved her eyebrows, revealing a small canine tooth, her gaze sweeping over the two before finally settling on Wenzhen's face with an unmistakable aggressive intensity.

Feng Yue in the kitchen had just come out carrying a plate when she heard Fu Sixue say this.

"Little devil, starting again?" Feng Yue's words interrupted the three's conversation, "We can start eating soon."

Hearing that they could eat, Fu Sixue, who had been full of aggressive energy, immediately transformed back into her original harmless loli appearance, happily rushing to the dining table.

Zhou Qiongqiong also quickly recovered from the earlier atmosphere. Having been Fu Sixue's classmate for a year, she had some experience with her rapid face-changing abilities.

"You little devil! You dare to scare me! Watch me nip you in the bud!" She said, then also rushed to the dining table, leaving only Wenzhen still sitting on the sofa.

Wenzhen, sitting on the sofa, barely came back to her senses. The extremely strong aggressive feeling that had burst from Fu Sixue just now gave her the illusion of being targeted as prey by a ferocious beast.

Her intuition told her that this seemingly harmless and adorable little loli was definitely not as simple as she appeared.

She should stay away from her, or at least maintain some distance.

Footnotes:

1. **Housewarming party (暖屋宴)** - A Chinese tradition of hosting a gathering to celebrate moving into a new home, similar to a housewarming party in Western culture.
2. **Graduation thesis (毕设)** - Short for "graduation design" (毕业设计), referring to the final project or thesis that Chinese university students must complete to graduate.
3. **Auntie (阿姨)** - In this context, refers to a domestic helper or housekeeper, commonly called "auntie" as a respectful term in Chinese culture.